

Modal Jazz Continuation - Lecture Notes

WithAI Research

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Course Context

Reading Assignment: Chapter 3 - "Chad's Compositions and Beagles from the Nation"

Key Reading Highlights:

- Jazz musicians typically learn pieces in all 12 keys (p. 66)
- Bebop was the first style that emphasized practicing in all 12 keys
- Chord progressions serve as a roadmap for musicians (p. 71)
- Many jazz standards are learned by ear (p. 72)
- Learning the blues is typically the first step in jazz improvisation (p. 76)
- Simple structure: one scale and four chord progressions
- Chord substitution as a method to enrich harmony (p. 85)

Book Context: Paul Berliner's *Thinking in Jazz* (1994) - one of the first comprehensive musicology texts on jazz

Wayne Shorter

Biography

- **Born:** 1933, Newark, New Jersey
- **Died:** Recently (in his late 80s)
- **Significance:** One of the most important composers and saxophonists in jazz history

Career Highlights

- Started mainstream career with **Art Blakey's Jazz Messengers** (1960)
- Initially sounded similar to young John Coltrane
- Joined **Miles Davis's Second Great Quintet** (1964)
- Primary composer for the group during the 1960s
- Worked alongside Herbie Hancock, Ron Carter, and Tony Williams
- Co-founded **Weather Report** (1970s)
- Important fusion group (jazz + rock)

Musical Style

- Unique harmonic sensibility
- Beautiful melodic writing
- Distinct from Coltrane despite initial similarities
- Favored single-note lines and rhythmic development
- Dramatic use of space and dynamics

Key Recording: *Speak No Evil* (1964)

Personnel:

- Wayne Shorter - tenor saxophone
- Freddie Hubbard - trumpet

- Herbie Hancock - piano
- Ron Carter - bass
- Elvin Jones - drums

Recorded: December 24, 1964

Musical Characteristics:

- Modal jazz approach
- Emphasis on rhythmic elements over harmonic expansion
- Less "sheets of sound" approach compared to Coltrane
- Herbie Hancock's sophisticated accompaniment

John Coltrane - *A Love Supreme*

Recording Details

- **Recorded:** December 9, 1964 (two weeks before *Speak No Evil*)
- **Label:** Impulse Records
- **Significance:** Most famous Coltrane work for non-jazz audiences

Historical Context

- Recorded at the transitional point in Coltrane's career
- Last major modal jazz recording before moving into free jazz (1965-67)
- Represents spiritual awakening Coltrane experienced in 1957
- Liner notes describe it as "musical praise to the Almighty"

Cultural Impact

- Synonymous with spiritual devotion in jazz
- Referenced frequently by scholar **Cornel West** (Harvard professor, public intellectual, theologian)
- Four-movement suite structure

"Acknowledgment" (First Movement)

Personnel:

- John Coltrane - tenor saxophone
- McCoy Tyner - piano
- Jimmy Garrison - bass
- Elvin Jones - drums

Notable Features:

- Famous "A Love Supreme" vocal chant at the end
- Coltrane overdubbed his voice twice (only two voices, not more)
- Only take with the chant on it became the master
- Upper register "reaching" sound - emblematic of Coltrane's later style

Alternate Versions:

- Original sessions included **Archie Shepp** (tenor sax) and **Art Davis** (bass)

- These takes were discovered and released ~25 years later
- *A Love Supreme: Live in Seattle* - features **Pharaoh Sanders** (released recently)

Coltrane's Stylistic Evolution

- Earlier sound (with Miles): smoother, more bebop-oriented
- *A Love Supreme* era: harder, thicker tone; more vibrato
- Later period (1965-67): free jazz; fractured lines; screaming/shouting sound in upper register

Comparison: Shorter vs. Coltrane

Similarities:

- Both recorded within two weeks (Dec 1964)
- Both using modal jazz framework
- Similar tenor saxophone timbres
- Driving, energetic rhythm sections

Differences:

- Shorter: rhythmic emphasis, dramatic space, single-note development
- Coltrane: harmonic expansion, "sheets of sound," spiritual intensity, upper register exploration

Dave Brubeck

Biography

- **Born:** 1920, San Francisco
- **Died:** 2012 (age 91)
- **Style:** Cool jazz, West Coast jazz scene

The Dave Brubeck Quartet (founded 1951)

Key Personnel:

- Dave Brubeck - piano
- **Paul Desmond** - alto saxophone
- Eugene Wright - bass
- Joe Morello - drums

Historical Controversy: Time Magazine Cover (1954)

The Issue:

- *Time* magazine did first-ever cover story on American jazz
- Featured Dave Brubeck (white musician) on cover
- **Miles Davis, Duke Ellington, Louis Armstrong** (Black musicians) had never been featured
- Caused controversy in jazz community

Brubeck's Response (from Ken Burns's *Jazz* documentary):

- Expressed embarrassment about being chosen
- Acknowledged more deserving artists (Miles, Duke, Louis)

- Recognized the racial dynamics of the decision
- Context: 1954 was early Civil Rights era, just before Dr. Martin Luther King Jr.'s prominence

***Time Out* (1959) and "Take Five"**

Album Context:

- Recorded same year as *Kind of Blue*
- Year before *My Favorite Things*

"Take Five" Details:

- **Composed by Paul Desmond** (not Brubeck)
- In **5/4 time signature** - unusual for jazz at the time
- Most jazz was in 4/4 or 3/4
- Modal jazz structure (ostinato over E $\blacksquare$ minor)
- Bridge has chord changes, but main section is modal
- Became one of the most iconic jazz pieces alongside "Sing, Sing, Sing" and "So What"

Musical Characteristics:

- Cool jazz sound: laid back, lighter tone, less vibrato
- Paul Desmond's alto: very different from Charlie Parker's bebop style
- Hypnotic bass ostinato (similar intensity to "My Favorite Things")
- Accessible melody - more commercializable than hard bop
- Mixture of percussion and piano with rhythmic interplay
- Energy fluctuates: intense middle section, then returns to laid-back feel

Stan Getz and Bossa Nova

Stan Getz Biography

- **Born:** 1927, Philadelphia
- **Died:** 1991, California (age 64)
- Moved to New York in late 1930s
- Sound rooted in **Lester Young's** cool jazz approach
- Could also play bebop at fast tempos

Bossa Nova Movement (1960s)

What is Bossa Nova?

- Fusion of American jazz + Brazilian samba
- Created by **Antonio Carlos Jobim** and **João Gilberto** (Brazil)
- Became a craze in 1960s America
- Bridge between cool jazz and Latin music

Impact on Jazz:

- Many musicians recorded bossa nova albums
- Hard bop musicians like **Cannonball Adderley** recorded bossa nova albums
- Demonstrated jazz's capacity for cross-cultural fusion

"The Girl from Ipanema" (Getz/Gilberto, 1964)

Personnel:

- Stan Getz - tenor saxophone
- João Gilberto - guitar/vocals
- **Astrud Gilberto** - vocals (English lyrics)
- Antonio Carlos Jobim - piano

Cultural Impact:

- One of the most iconic recordings in jazz history
- Grammy Award winner
- Played at Olympics opening ceremony in Brazil (Giselle Bündchen walked to it)
- Represents Brazil internationally

Musical Characteristics:

- Very laid back, nonchalant feel
- Breathy saxophone tone
- Not virtuosic in the Ella Fitzgerald sense - adds to cool ambiance
- "Cool" rather than "hot" jazz
- Gentle, sustained accompaniment (not constant rhythmic drive)
- Astrud Gilberto's vocal approach: simple, understated, breathy

Andrew Hill - *Point of Departure*

Andrew Hill Biography

- **Born:** 1931, Chicago
- **Died:** 2007 (age 75)
- Moved to New York City in 1961
- Signed with **Blue Note Records** (1963)

Musical Style

- Similar to **Thelonious Monk** in uniqueness - didn't sound like anyone else
- Did not achieve the same popularity as contemporaries
- Considered a "classic composer" within the jazz idiom
- Pushing boundaries of modal jazz toward free jazz

Point of Departure (1964) - "Refuge"

Title Significance: "Point of Departure" aptly describes transition in jazz happening at this time

Personnel:

- Andrew Hill - piano
- **Kenny Dorham** - trumpet (played with Charlie Parker)
- **Joe Henderson** - tenor saxophone
- **Eric Dolphy** - alto saxophone (important free jazz musician)
- Richard Davis - bass

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- **Tony Williams** - drums (from Miles Davis's group)

Recorded: 1964

Musical Characteristics:

- Still modal jazz but pushing boundaries
- Very dense texture
- **Angular and dissonant**
- Close voicings and complex harmonies
- Structure: piano ostinato returns after each wind solo
- Winds return with harmonic melody after rhythm section features
- **Impressionist influence** (similar to Debussy/Ravel)
- Mixture of accessibility and complexity

Student Reactions:

- "Made sense and didn't make sense at the same time"
- Dense, angular, dissonant
- Structured despite complexity
- Blend of jazz and impressionism

Assignment Reminder

Paper Requirements:

- Must cite sources
- Works cited page required
- Due after spring break

Next Class

Topic: Continuation into Free Jazz

- Eric Dolphy and others
- After spring break (April 18)

Key Themes from This Lecture

1. **Modal Jazz Variations:** Different approaches by Shorter, Coltrane, Brubeck
 2. **Cool Jazz:** Laid-back, lighter tone (Brubeck, Getz, Desmond)
 3. **Cultural Fusion:** Bossa nova as bridge between jazz and Brazilian music
 4. **Racial Dynamics in Jazz History:** Time magazine controversy (1954)
 5. **Transition Period:** 1964 as pivotal year - modal jazz beginning to transform into free jazz
 6. **Spirituality in Jazz:** Coltrane's *A Love Supreme* as musical devotion
 7. **Innovation in Time Signatures:** Brubeck's use of 5/4 time
 8. **Compositional Approaches:** Shorter as composer vs. Coltrane as improviser/explorer
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Listening Recommendations

- Wayne Shorter - *Speak No Evil* (complete album)
- John Coltrane - *A Love Supreme* (all four movements)
- Alternate versions with Archie Shepp and Art Davis
- *A Love Supreme: Live in Seattle*
- Dave Brubeck - *Time Out* (complete album)
- Stan Getz/João Gilberto - *Getz/Gilberto*
- Andrew Hill - *Point of Departure* (complete album)